

THE CALORIE MATH BEHIND A CONTROLLED BULK

From BMR to a smart surplus, the exact numbers behind building size without the fat.

"Eat more" is correct advice for building size, and it is also nowhere near specific enough to actually act on. How much more, exactly? The answer is not a guess or a number you round up to "big," it is a calculation that starts with your own body and ends with a surplus sized to build muscle, not just add weight.

Step One: Your BMR

Basal metabolic rate (BMR) is the energy your body burns at rest, before any training or daily movement is added in. The Mifflin-St Jeor equation estimates it from weight, height, and age:

- **Men:** $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) + 5$
- **Women:** $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) - 161$

Take a 24-year-old man starting a bulking block, 75 kg (about 165 lbs), 180 cm tall (about 5'11"), a couple years of lifting behind him but still relatively lean. His BMR: $(10 \times 75) + (6.25 \times 180) - (5 \times 24) + 5 = 750 + 1,125 - 120 + 5 = \mathbf{1,760 \text{ calories}}$.

Step Two: BMR to TDEE

Multiply BMR by an activity multiplier to find total daily energy expenditure (TDEE), the calories it takes to maintain his current weight: sedentary $\times 1.2$, lightly active $\times 1.375$, moderately active $\times 1.55$, very active $\times 1.725$. A 4-day upper/lower bulking split like Echelon's base model puts him at moderately active. $1,760 \times 1.55 = \mathbf{2,728 \text{ calories}}$, his maintenance number.

Step Three: Sizing the Surplus

This is where a bulk is won or lost before a single meal is eaten. A controlled surplus of roughly **10-20% above TDEE** gives your body the extra energy it needs to build new tissue without so much excess that the majority of it turns to fat. For our example, that is 2,728 plus 10-20%, landing him around **3,000 to 3,275 calories a day**, roughly 275 to 550 extra calories above maintenance. That is a controlled bulk, not the "eat everything in sight" approach that tends to add fat a lot faster than it adds muscle.

Filling the Surplus With the Right Foods

More total food is genuinely part of the plan here, which is exactly why food quality still matters, arguably more than on a maintenance diet, since you are asking your body to process a larger volume of food

consistently. Build meals around a solid protein portion at every sitting, a carbohydrate portion sized to that day's training demands, and a moderate amount of fat, then let whole, minimally processed foods do most of the work with room for less structured food in moderation.

How to Tell If the Number Is Actually Right

The calculation above is a starting point, not a guarantee, everyone's real-world metabolism varies a bit from what a formula predicts. The way to check if a surplus is sized correctly is to track trend weight over two to three weeks, not any single day. A good target is roughly **0.25-0.5% of bodyweight gained per week**, for our 75 kg example, that is somewhere around 0.2-0.4 kg (under a pound) a week. Faster than that, and the extra calories are likely landing mostly as fat rather than muscle, which is the cue to trim the surplus back down, not push it higher.

Supplement Support for a Bulk

Eating enough protein across a genuinely higher calorie target can be a real logistical challenge, a whey option like **XS™ Whey Protein** is a simple way to add protein without piling on more food volume than you can comfortably eat. **XS™ Creatine+** is also worth a look for anyone training hard through a bulking block, it is a training-performance and strength-support option, relevant here since the entire point of the surplus is to fuel the lifting that is actually driving growth. Both are available through [the Echelon Goods shop](#).

What This Means for You

- Your surplus target starts with BMR (Mifflin-St Jeor), multiplied by an activity factor for TDEE, then adjusted up, not guessed at.
- A 10-20% surplus above TDEE is the general range for controlled, mostly-muscle growth, bigger isn't better past that point.
- Food quality matters more, not less, when total intake goes up, it is what makes eating that much food sustainable.
- Recalculate every several weeks as your weight climbs, your maintenance number rises along with your body weight.

This article is educational and general in nature, not individualized medical or nutrition advice. If you have a medical condition or are taking medication, talk to your doctor before making significant changes to your diet or training volume.